

Sea horse

Sea horses are very unusual fish. The spotted sea horse has armor instead of scales. It has eyes that move independently, fins so tiny that it has trouble swimming, and a tail that can grab objects and other sea horses. Strangest of all, it is the father who protects the eggs in his pouch, feeds them with nutrients, and even gives birth.

Courtship

When a female sea horse is ready to mate, she moves closer to the male and starts a courtship dance, nodding her head toward him. The male may inflate his pouch in response.

Courting sea horses often swim holding each other's tails.

The sea horses can dance together for hours, even days.

After the female transfers her eggs, she looks thinner and the male fatter.

Pregnant male

The male's pouch is similar in some ways to the uterus, or womb, of a female mammal. The male produces nutrients, including some from seawater, that seep into the pouch and keep the eggs healthy.

Egg transfer

The courtship dance ends with the female transferring her eggs to the male. The female inserts a tube into the male's pouch and passes her eggs to him. The eggs are then fertilized in the male's pouch.